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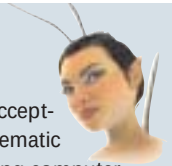
Cinematic Computing

Typically, a feature-length animated 3D film takes over three years to complete. Most of this time is taken up by the rendering process. Every second of animation is composed of 24 frames, or still images, which, when displayed rapidly, produce the illusion of motion. Therefore, in a two-hour movie, for example, you'd have 7,200 seconds, or $7200 \times 24 = 1,72,800$ frames.

It takes around 8 hours for a high-end machine to render each highly-detailed individual frame. Therefore, another multiplication reveals that the time required to render the whole movie will be $1,72,800 \times 8 = 1,382,400$ hours, or roughly 158 years to make one movie. Since this far exceeds the average life expectancy, studios use thousands of computers—called rendering

farms—simultaneously to get the movie to theatres in an acceptable timeframe. This is where cinematic computing comes in. While playing computer games, the PC needs to render 24 frames every second, in real-time. To achieve this speed, it has to make huge compromises in quality, making what you see on the computer screen, far removed from what you see on the movie screen.

However, with advances in technology, we get more and more powerful graphic processors. With this equipment, game developers are now in a position to increase the quality of the video card's output, gradually reaching the level of an animated movie. This concept of creating ultra-high quality graphics in very rapid times is called Cinematic Computing.



it would be better had they used Indian mythological characters instead?

You know what's a scary thing? I don't think Indians would buy games with Indian stars! It's funny, because you make a lot of Indian movies, more than Hollywood, with Indian characters and content. And yet, in the games industry, you only play Westerners. It's weird! (laughs) So I think that if the same sensibilities that Indian movies have were taken to games as well, it'd be a good thing.

■ Any Indian entities you've come across that hold great promise?

Everyone I met so far has shown great promise. You've got so many new faces that are really willing to learn. It's that spark that sets a game company apart from one that's just doing its job and plodding along, churning out boring games. So if you project that with the absorption of new skills, you're going to see some pretty awesome work.

Already, a lot of the world's coding work is done in India. If you show the game industries in America, England and even Korea or China what you can do, you'll see a lot more outsourcing companies springing up.

■ So what are the distinct skills of Indian game companies?

I was really happy to see that in *BattleDust*, they spent so much time on the Indian temple level, and it shows. If you look at the other levels in comparison, it really shows. I think India doesn't have a style to speak of yet. Japan has a style, Australia has one, and America has one or two styles. You can look at a Japanese game and recognise it instantly. I imagine we'll eventually see one for India.

■ Which is your favourite game? Any genre you prefer?

I like thinking man's first person shooters. So

Counter-Strike for me is the most well-balanced game I've ever played. I loved *Dead or Alive 2*. When you play with another *DOA2* player, it's like playing chess, because you make one mistake, and your opponent's going to trash you. So eventually it becomes a staring contest, where you become almost Zen-like, and then suddenly 'paba-paba-paba', and you're dead. *DOA3* kind of like threw a spanner in the works there, but I love that series a lot. I played *Deus Ex* for about 20 minutes, but couldn't find the time to play it more. My favourite game of all time at the moment is *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* for the Xbox. The reason is, I'm a *Buffy* fan, and I thought that anything that even tried to work on *Buffy* would be terrible. And yet the game was so good. I haven't played the sequel, but I'm waiting for that.

One game I'm really itching for now is *DOOM III*. *Half-Life 2* looks great, but I'm interested in seeing what Id's going to do. It's just got so much atmosphere and mood to it. I want to shoot a zombie down the stairs. I'm dying to do that. I've been very good—I haven't touched the alpha version that leaked out. I'm waiting for them to finish the game, and buy the full version.

■ What do you think of the mobile game market?

Mobiles are a great place to start. All you need is one Java programmer, one pixel-pusher. I'll tell you what, I saw some of these Korean mobile phones, and brace yourself guys, there's some great shit coming your way. It's like full 3D phones. Not sprites, 3D is very rudimentary, but it's there. So I'm sure you'll be playing *Quake I* on these things soon. Wow! (laughs) So brace yourselves, because there's some pretty crazy things those Koreans are cooking up right now. All I want is a mobile phone that opens like Neo's! ☞

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